

DON'T LET THE DEAL STEAL FROM YOU

CYBERSECURITY LEADERS ON OUTSMARTING FESTIVE SCAMMERS BEFORE THEY OUTSMART YOU

By **Jayesh Shinde** | editor@digit.in

Brands spend months planning their festive sales, and so do fraudsters. Fake storefronts, doctored delivery texts, impersonation calls and too-good-to-be-true discounts all peak when India is busiest shopping. We asked leaders from across the cybersecurity and consumer protection space what's changed this year, and how shoppers can keep their money safe once the festive rush takes over.



ONE WRONG LETTER AWAY

"Every festive season, the same story repeats itself, just with better tactics. A recent industry survey found that nearly one in three Indian shoppers fell for an online scam last festive period, and more than a third of them lost actual money. The tactics keep evolving. Fake stores now use web addresses that look almost identical to the real brand, one wrong letter or a swapped domain ending is often the only giveaway. Ads promising 80 or 90 percent off pull people in before they think twice. Then there are the delivery texts, the ones claiming your parcel is stuck, asking you to click and "verify" your details. Even reviews aren't safe anymore, plenty of fraudulent sites are propped up by fake ratings designed purely to earn your trust.

None of this is unbeatable though. Type the store's address into your browser yourself instead of clicking links from an SMS or an ad. Look for the padlock and https before you enter any payment information. Pay with a credit card where possible, it gives you far better recourse if something goes wrong, unlike a direct bank transfer. Skip shopping over public Wi-Fi. If a seller feels unfamiliar, you should search their name with the word scam attached and see what turns up. Turn on two factor authentication on your accounts. And if you do get caught out, report it immediately to your bank and the Cyber Crime portal, acting fast genuinely helps.

Being careful here isn't paranoia, it's just good practice before the festive rush hits full swing."

– TARUN WIG
Co-Founder and CEO, Innefu Labs